Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Marianne Moore's "Silence"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of these poems include

allusion,
ambiguity,
ambivalence,
imagery,
irony,
litotes,
simile, and
tone.

The young writer might focus solely on the simile, pointing to the grimness or the morbidity of the image of a cat with a dead mouse in its mouth. The comparison of superior people to cats that seek out solitude, which is a fairly natural comparison, is made specific, if not memorable, with the reason for the cat's having sought solitude: the capture of something it wants. The father's noting that superior people might find solace ("enjoying solitude)" in taking for their own someone else's words ("robbed of speech / by speech which has delighted them") might be recognized as ironic: the persona, the daughter (?), has appropriated the father's words. Thus the poem's tone might be understood in terms of the daughter's take on the quality of her father's advice. The poem's autobiographical nature sets up an ambiguity for the reader meeting the poem for the first time. Any discussion of the poem's tone or the persona's attitude toward her father or her father's advice might be a bit off target; this should not be a problem, however; any discussion of tone that depends on support directly from the poem should be deemed literary analysis.

The competitor might focus on the poem's last line, which seems to be a defiant contradicting of the line borrowed from Burke, "Make my house your inn." A discussion of the poem's tone that begins with the persona's seeming contracting of her father's maxim-like invitation might recognize the simile's morbidity and perhaps make something of the inherent morbidity of "Longfellow's grave." Such an approach to the poem might point to a significance of the silence of the grave, the silence of the cat's mouth, and the active silence of restraint (line 12). The tone then depends on recognizing the last line as a rejection. "Inns are not residences" suggests a loud negating of the silence that seems to please the father.